



**THE
KEYS
COACH**

FREE LESSON BOOK

THE ESSENTIAL FUNK FORMULA

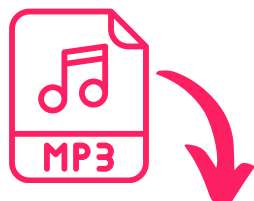
THEKEYSCOACH.COM



This lesson book goes alongside the full-length tutorial video on The Keys Coach YouTube channel.



Adam Saunders
Founder
The Keys Coach



Backing Track

You can download the Backing Track used in video for free.

There is no keys on the track — just the band.

There are two tempos (**Regular** and **Slower**)

 [Slower Tempo \(Click Here\)](#)

 [Regular Tempo \(Click Here\)](#)

Hi! 

I'm Adam, and if we haven't met before, I help piano players find confidence, freedom, and creativity on the piano.

Funk is one of my favorite styles to play—the grooves are infectious, and there's nothing quite like locking into a rhythm and jamming in a funk band.

After years of playing in various funk bands, I've developed a go-to approach for crafting killer funk grooves on the keys.

In this lesson book (and the accompanying video), I'm going to break down what I call **the Funk Formula**—a step-by-step method I use every time I create a funky groove.

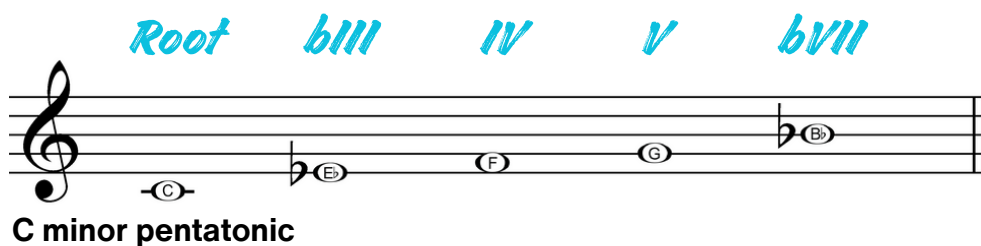
This formula will help you build grooves that don't just sound great but feel authentic—just like the great funk players, from Herbie Hancock to Stevie Wonder and beyond.

Let's Dive In!

The Minor Pentatonic

Watch at 0:29

So much of what we're going to be doing in this lesson, revolves around the minor pentatonic. We're in the key of C minor, so we'll be using the **C minor pentatonic scale**.



Get this scale really secure under your fingers before moving on.

Many funk keyboard players rely on repetitive patterns and riffs. While it might sound like there's a lot happening, they're often **just using notes from a pentatonic scale**.

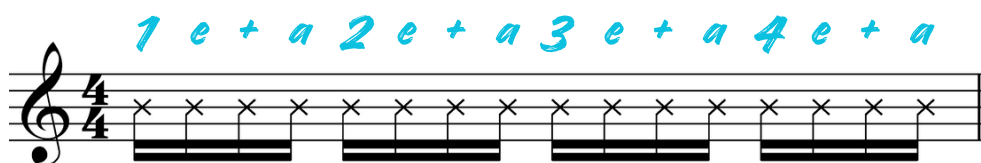


"The minor pentatonic is one of the most **versatile scales** – it's one of those that fits so many styles and instantly sounds great!"

The Funk Subdivision

Watch at 2:24

The subdivided beat is so important when playing funk. Instead of thinking of four main beats in a bar, divide each beat into four, which is known as a 16th note.



Whenever you're playing this style, make sure you keep subdividing the beat in your head.

Right Hand Riff

Watch at 2:50

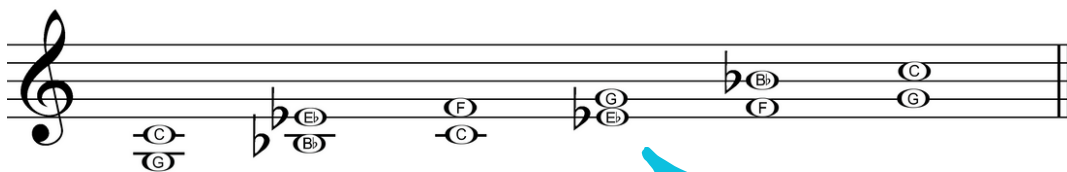
Here's the right-hand riff that Adam demonstrates in the video. It uses notes from the C minor pentatonic scale.



Important: In the video, when breaking down the rhythm, Adam plays the first half of each bar slightly differently than later on. The rhythm written here is how he demonstrates it in the breakdown. On the next page, you'll see how the rhythm is tweaked slightly.

Now, we're going to add a note beneath the melody in our right hand. To do this, we'll use 4ths.

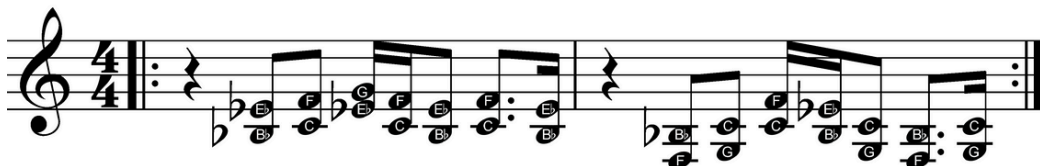
First, let's revisit our C minor pentatonic scale and harmonize it by adding a note a 4th below each of the notes in the scale.



"Note that this one's a third, not a fourth! A fourth below G would be D, but D isn't in the C minor pentatonic scale, so we've tweaked it to a third."

Right Hand Riff (continued)

Here is the pattern harmonized in 4ths, as demonstrated in the video.



This is the alternative rhythm Adam uses from this point onwards. The second beat of each bar uses 8th notes instead of 16th notes. It's a subtle difference, but important to point out to avoid confusion.

Notice that nothing is played on the first beat of each bar—the rhythm of the pattern comes in on beat 2.

Try playing this along with the backing track, linked at the beginning of this lesson book.

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 Will

★★★★★ A structured introduction to music theory which gets you applying it right away
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Left Hand Punctuations

Watch at 6:31

Now let's add our left hand to the pattern. In funk, the left hand acts as punctuation, adding drive and energy to the groove.

Here's the pattern Adam breaks down in the video (it's a two-bar pattern, repeated):

The musical notation shows a two-bar funk pattern in 4/4 time. The right hand (treble clef) plays a melody using the minor pentatonic scale (Bb, C, D, Eb, F). The left hand (bass clef) plays a bass line that punctuates the melody. The pattern is repeated twice.



"Think of the punctuation notes as gestures rather than 'actual' notes – they can be quite quiet and they essentially fill in the gaps."

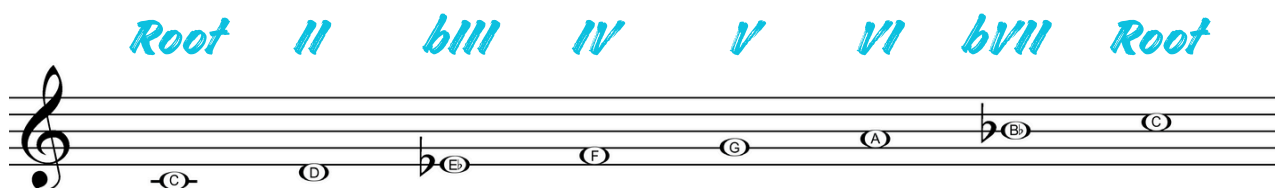
If you want to get creative and come up with your own pattern:

1. Create a catchy, riffy melody in your right hand using the minor pentatonic scale.
2. Harmonize it in 4ths.
3. Rhythmically punctuate the riff with your left hand by playing in the gaps.

Funk Triads

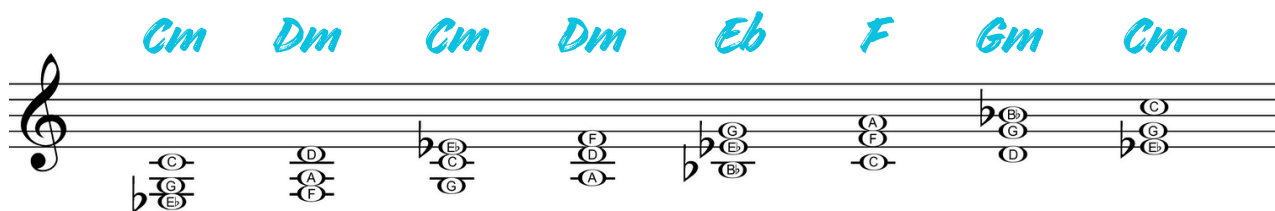
Watch at 10:41

We're now going to move away from the minor pentatonic and use the **C Dorian scale** instead. It's very similar to the minor pentatonic, but with the 2nd and 6th added.

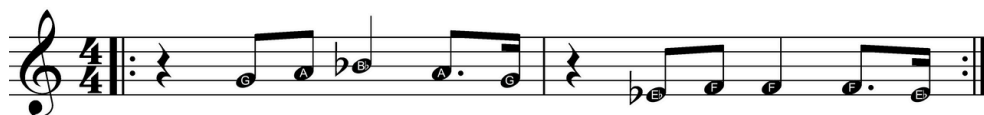


C Dorian

We're now going to harmonize every note in this scale using triads, but only using notes from the C Dorian scale.



Now, let's create a right-hand riff using notes from the C Dorian scale. Start by focusing on the top note—the melody.



Now harmonise it using the triads shown above:



Funk Triads (continued)

You can also add little **grace notes** in the middle of your chords by sliding up a semitone to the middle note in some of the chords. This is really common in funk!



Try playing this through with the backing track, focusing on the rhythm and really locking into the groove.

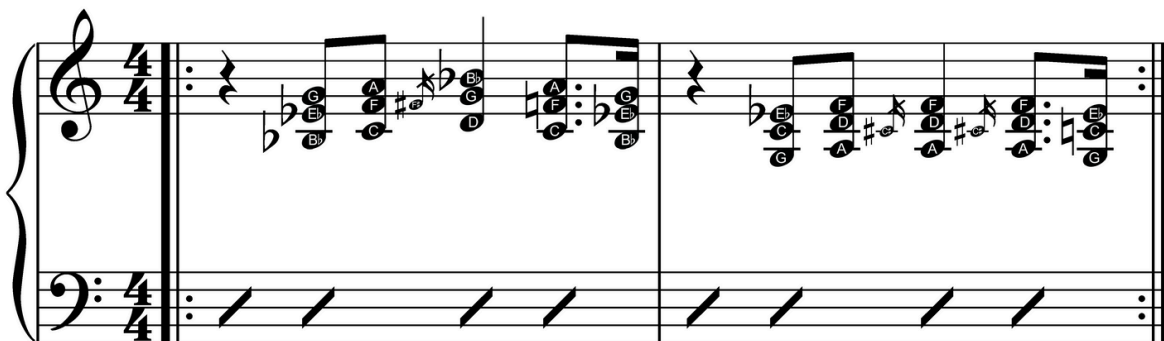
Choppy Left Hand

Watch at 14:56

Now, have a go at punctuating the groove with your left hand.

Try to spot the gaps in the right-hand pattern. In the example below, notice the left-hand part is blank—try adding your own left-hand punctuations.

You can use your left-hand thumb, and if you want to take it up a level, you can occasionally use your right-hand thumb, as Adam demonstrates in the video.



The Lick

Watch at 17:22

Here is the lick that Adam demonstrates in the video. It kicks off the whole groove and is a great workout (quite tricky to play!)

The image displays two musical staves. The top staff, labeled 'the lick', shows a complex melodic line in the treble clef and a corresponding bass line in the bass clef. The bottom staff, labeled 'Groove starts here', shows a series of chords in the treble clef and a bass line in the bass clef. The key signature is one sharp (F#). The top staff ends with a G7#5#9 chord. The bottom staff starts with a Cm7 chord.

Next Steps...



Adam Saunders
Founder
The Keys Coach

There's a lot to work on in with this lesson! Take your time going through it, and remember—playing along with the backing track is key to improving your rhythm, groove and so many other aspects of your playing.

By the way, if you've enjoyed this video, drop us an email—we love hearing from people who are finding the lessons helpful!

You can reach us at hello@thekeyscoach.com.

Cheers!



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